



SAFE

Keeping perishable cooked foods like chicken chilled below 40°F and consuming them within 2 hours prevents harmful bacterial growth. This practice fits the 2-hour rule recommended for food safety in warm conditions, especially important for protein-rich foods. Proper cooling and timely consumption are key to preventing foodborne illness.

Source: SP 50-814 Summer food safety



NOT SAFE

A bulging lid and off odors in home-canned low-acid foods signal possible bacterial growth including dangerous botulism toxin. Such cans must never be opened or consumed. These are clear signs of spoilage and pose a serious health risk.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism



IT DEPENDS

Safety hinges on the acidity level and processing adjustments for altitude. Tomatoes are borderline in acidity; without added acid like lemon juice or citric acid, the salsa may be unsafe in a boiling water bath. Also, altitude requires longer processing time or higher pressure to destroy pathogens. Without proper acidification and altitude adjustment, canned salsa may be unsafe.

Source: SP 50-1001 PH values



SAFE

Following a research-tested recipe for canning fruits ensures safety by using the correct processing time, temperature, and headspace. Boiling water canning is safe for high-acid fruits when volume, acidity, and jar size are correct, and altitude adjustments are made. Using clean, heat-tempered jars and new lids also ensures a proper seal and prevents spoilage.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



NOT SAFE

Underripe fruit is less acidic and may not be safely processed with standard boiling water canning times. Raw packing without preheating and underprocessing can lead to spoilage or growth of dangerous microorganisms, including botulism. Always use ripe fruit and follow tested recipes and processing times precisely.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



IT DEPENDS

Processing times for canning fruits must be adjusted for altitude as boiling temperature decreases at higher elevations. Not adjusting for altitude can result in inadequate heat treatment, risking spoilage or unsafe food. You must increase processing time or boiling water temperature by following altitude adjustment guidance to ensure safety.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



SAFE

This salsa is safe because it follows a research-tested recipe that ensures enough acidity by adding bottled lemon juice, uses the proper processing time in a boiling water canner, and uses high-quality, fresh tomatoes. Processing time and acidity are critical to prevent botulism in salsas, which contain low-acid ingredients mixed with tomatoes. Following exact recipes and methods that have been lab-tested guarantees safety.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning



NOT SAFE

Not adding bottled lemon juice or vinegar can result in inadequate acidity, allowing *Clostridium botulinum* bacteria to grow, which can cause botulism—a serious foodborne illness. Also, under-processing (shorter than recommended time) does not safely eliminate bacteria. Salsa must have controlled acidity and proper processing time to be safe.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning



IT DEPENDS

The safety depends on the exact acidity level of your salsa. Without a tested recipe specifying acid type and amount, you cannot be sure the acid level is sufficient to prevent botulism. The processing time is adequate if acidity is correct, but unknown acidity means the risk cannot be ruled out. Untested recipes should only be frozen or refrigerated, not canned.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning



SAFE

Using a tested recipe with the correct processing time, headspace, and altitude adjustment ensures the destruction of *Clostridium botulinum* spores in low-acid foods. Correct equipment maintenance, like accurate pressure gauges, is critical for safety. Pressure canning reaches the necessary temperature (240°F) that boiling water canners cannot achieve.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game



NOT SAFE

Spaghetti sauce with meat is a low-acid food and must be processed in a pressure canner, not a boiling water canner. Boiling water cannot reach the 240°F needed to kill botulism spores. Processing low-acid foods incorrectly risks deadly botulism poisoning, even if the food looks and smells normal.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game



IT DEPENDS

Garlic in oil is a low-acid food and can support *Clostridium botulinum* growth without proper acidification. Commercial products are acidified to prevent bacterial growth. Safety depends precisely on following tested acidification procedures; if acidification is incomplete or inconsistent, the product is unsafe at room temperature. Otherwise, it must be refrigerated or frozen.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home



SAFE

Following a tested recipe ensures the correct acidity and processing time to prevent bacterial growth and spoilage. Using the proper vinegar concentration and processing time adjusted for altitude guarantees safety. Proper headspace and clean jars prevent contamination and allow for adequate heat penetration during processing.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables



NOT SAFE

Homemade vinegar can vary widely in acidity and may not reach the critical 5% acidity needed to safely inhibit bacterial growth. Without proper acid levels and heat processing, harmful bacteria, including *Clostridium botulinum*, can grow leading to poisoning. Processing ensures destruction of pathogens.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables



IT DEPENDS

Quick pickles require boiling water processing to ensure safety, but processing time must be adjusted for altitude. At 4,000 feet, processing time is longer to compensate for lower boiling temperature. Without proper adjustment, safety is not guaranteed.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables



SAFE

Using low-methoxyl pectin for low-sugar jams is safe because it's designed to set without high sugar levels. Processing in a boiling water canner for the recommended time ensures destruction of molds and pathogens. Refrigeration after opening prevents spoilage.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home



NOT SAFE

Mold on jams and jellies can contaminate the entire product below the surface, and molds may produce dangerous mycotoxins. It is unsafe to simply remove mold and consume the rest. The entire jar should be discarded to prevent illness.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home



IT DEPENDS

Pepper jellies with low-acid vegetables depend on added acid (like vinegar or lemon juice) for safety. Without sufficient acidification, processing alone cannot guarantee safe acidity (pH below 4.6), risking botulism. Safety depends on following a tested recipe that includes acid.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home



SAFE

Freezing cooked soup right after rapid cooling prevents harmful bacterial growth. Using airtight containers and a freezer at 0°F (-18°C) maintains safety and quality. Labeling with dates helps with proper food rotation and timely use to maintain quality.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home



NOT SAFE

When canned foods freeze and cans bulge or seams break, the risk of spoilage increases. Using thawed canned foods with bulging or damaged cans without further heat treatment can expose you to dangerous bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum*. Such foods should be discarded or boiled 10 minutes before using if still safe physically.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home



IT DEPENDS

Safety depends on how long the beans were above 40°F. If they stayed above 40°F for less than 2 hours and still contain ice crystals, refreezing is generally safe though quality may suffer. Longer warm exposure can allow bacteria to grow, making refreezing unsafe. Cook immediately if unsure, or discard if suspect.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables



SAFE

Drying jerky safely requires drying meat at a temperature of at least 145°F to kill pathogens. Using a dehydrator with a thermostatically controlled temperature dial and confirming with an external thermometer helps ensure the safety of the dried product.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely



NOT SAFE

Smoking fish without monitoring internal temperature and time can allow harmful bacteria to survive, particularly *Clostridium botulinum*. Uncontrolled smoking is risky and can result in foodborne illness.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home



IT DEPENDS

The safety of drying tomatoes depends on ensuring the drying temperature is high enough (usually above 130°F) for a sufficient time to reduce moisture safely. Altitude affects drying times and temperatures needed. Without knowing these details or controlling temperature, safety cannot be assured.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables